BELIEF COUNSELING

Free Will, Pain, and Suffering

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> *"Pain insists upon being attended to. God whispers to us in our pleasures, speaks in our consciences, but shouts in our pains. It is his megaphone to rouse a deaf world."*
>
> — C.S. Lewis, *The Problem of Pain*

If you are hurting right now, whether in your body, your heart, or both, you have probably asked, "Why is this happening to me?" and maybe, "Is God doing this to me?" I have asked those questions too. I am a Christian psychologist, not a theologian, but I have spent many years thinking, reading, and praying about pain and suffering, and I live with chronic pain myself. I want to share with you what I have come to believe.

Where pain came from

When God created the world, it was perfect. There was no sin, no illness, and no disability, and people lived in harmony with God. But God gave Adam and Eve free will, and they used it to turn away from Him. From that moment, sin entered the world, and with it came sickness, injury, broken bodies, and broken hearts. God did not cause these problems. They came into the world through our free-will rebellion against Him.

So the first thing I want you to know is this: **your pain is not proof that God is against you.** We live in a fallen world, and everyone in it suffers in some way.

1. Your pain may have been caused by someone else.

Much of the suffering in this world is caused by other people's choices. If a drunk driver crashed into your car, your injuries did not come from anything *you* did. If you were abused as a child and now struggle with depression or anxiety, you did not cause what happened to you. Please don't carry blame that was never yours to carry.

2. God is not punishing you.

I do not believe that God arranges accidents, illnesses, or tragedies to punish people or to force them to "grow." When a drunk driver plows into another car and a young child dies, I do not believe God caused that for some hidden purpose. That would run contrary to everything we know about an all-loving God. In my opinion, that kind of suffering is the result of human free will and sin.

3. Does everything happen for a reason?

You may have heard someone say, “Everything happens for a reason.” That saying assumes God controls every event in the world. But God gave us free will to follow Him or to turn away from Him. If He controlled everything, there would be no sin, and there would be no pain or suffering.

God is **all-powerful**: He can do anything He chooses. He is **all-knowing**: He is aware of everything that happens, including your pain. And He is **everywhere**: He is right here with you. But being powerful, knowing, and present does not mean that He causes everything that happens. He holds back His power so that we can have free will.

4. Satan is real, and so are accidents.

As Christians, we believe there is another source of suffering: Satan. In the story of Job, God allowed Satan to test Job, and Job suffered terribly. Why God allows Satan any power in this world is a very big question, but Scripture makes clear that Satan’s influence brings real harm.

I also believe that sometimes accidents simply happen, without any hidden purpose on the part of God, people, or Satan. If I sneeze and wreck my car, I don’t try to figure out what God meant by it. If a baby dies of Sudden Infant Death Syndrome, I don’t believe God caused it so that the parents would learn a lesson. We are not in the Garden of Eden anymore. We live in a world with genetic problems, cancer, brain injuries, and miscarriages, and God did not send these things so that we could learn from them.

5. What you do with your pain matters.

I do not believe God caused an incredible man named Nick Vujicic to be born without arms and legs so that He could use him. God *allowed* Nick to be born this way, and He gave Nick the free will to turn toward Him or away from Him. Nick chose to turn to God, and that choice has made all the difference in his life and in the lives of countless others. His story is well worth hearing.



Watch Nick’s story

“Inspiring man born without arms or legs – Nick Vujicic,” *60 Minutes Australia*, on YouTube. Click the picture, or go to youtube.com/watch?v=tJnJ_fTYofQ

6. God’s plans for you are good.

The Bible makes it clear that God created you and has good plans for your life.

> *"For I know the plans I have for you," declares the LORD, "plans to prosper you and not to harm you, plans to give you hope and a future."*
>
> Jeremiah 29:11 (NIV)

Our free-will choices, and the choices of others, often get in the way of God's plans. But don't be afraid: God's purpose for this world will win in the end. His greatest desire is our salvation through Christ. He "wants all people to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth" (1 Timothy 2:4, NIV).

7. Turn to God.

Although I don't believe God causes our pain, He is always there for us to turn to when pain comes. When we turn to Him, we often grow stronger and deeper in our faith. You may never know exactly *why* this pain entered your life, but you can always bring it to God, the Creator of all things, for comfort and strength. God is love. Look up to Him, and let Him give you His peace and rest.

8. When you keep asking, "Why?"

I often admit that I really don't know *why* God allows certain kinds of suffering, such as the death of a child. The answer is too big for my little "pea brain." God's ways are not our ways, and His thoughts are not our thoughts (Isaiah 55:8). Instead of asking *why* over and over, try asking a different question: "What would You have me do now, Lord?" God may show you a way to use even this for good.

9. Look at your pain against the backdrop of heaven.

Our lives here are very short compared to eternity. Soon, very soon, we will see our Lord. We're not home yet. In the blink of an eye, we will be with Christ and see Him face to face, and we will be reunited with our loved ones in heaven, where there is no pain and no suffering. For Christians, "This is as bad as it gets." For those without Christ, "This is as good as it gets."

A Personal Note: Nick's Story and Mine

I have a very painful condition called peripheral neuropathy. I live with chronic pain, and I often need pain medication. I try not to, but sometimes I feel sorry for myself, and I get discouraged when I think about living the rest of my life with this pain.

One Sunday morning, as I started down the steps from my bedroom, my feet hurt as badly as ever. That morning, Nick Vujicic came to preach at my church. As he told his

story, I felt almost guilty when I heard how he had coped with his far greater challenges. In a flash, I realized how blessed my life has been, and the problem with my feet seemed almost trivial. I couldn't help thinking how much Nick would love to have my feet, just for a day, to walk down the steps instead of being carried. I was in tears as he told how he had turned to God.

Nick has a wonderful sense of humor. He told us that he always keeps a pair of shoes in his closet, *just in case God grants him a miracle*.

Another Way to See It: Childbirth

As the father of three children, I know a little about childbirth, and it gives us a helpful picture of the pain in this world.

A baby grows in the mother's womb for about forty weeks. That time can be uncomfortable, but it is extremely short compared to the seventy or eighty years that lie ahead for the child. When it is time to give birth, the mother usually goes through a great deal of pain, and the baby has a hard time too. But the moment she holds her baby in her arms, she begins to forget the pain. Before long, she hardly gives it a thought. Her eyes are on her new baby, and nothing will ever be the same again.

Now think of your own life. Our time on this earth is extremely short compared to eternity. When we are "born" into heaven, we probably won't even remember the pain and suffering we went through here.

> *"...because the former troubles are forgotten and are hidden from my eyes."* Isaiah 65:16 (ESV)
>
> *"For behold, I create new heavens and a new earth, and the former things shall not be remembered or come into mind."* Isaiah 65:17 (ESV)
>
> *"He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away."* Revelation 21:4 (NIV)

Like a mother after childbirth, we will find that the pain of this brief life is completely swallowed up by the joy and love we will know forever with our heavenly Father.

Bottom line: Your pain is real, but it is not God's punishment, and it is not the end of your story. Bring it to God, keep your eyes on eternity, and remember that soon we will live forever with our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ. Keep things in perspective!

If your pain ever feels like more than you can carry, please talk with your counselor, your pastor, or your doctor. If you ever have thoughts of ending your life, call or text **988** (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline) right away.

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